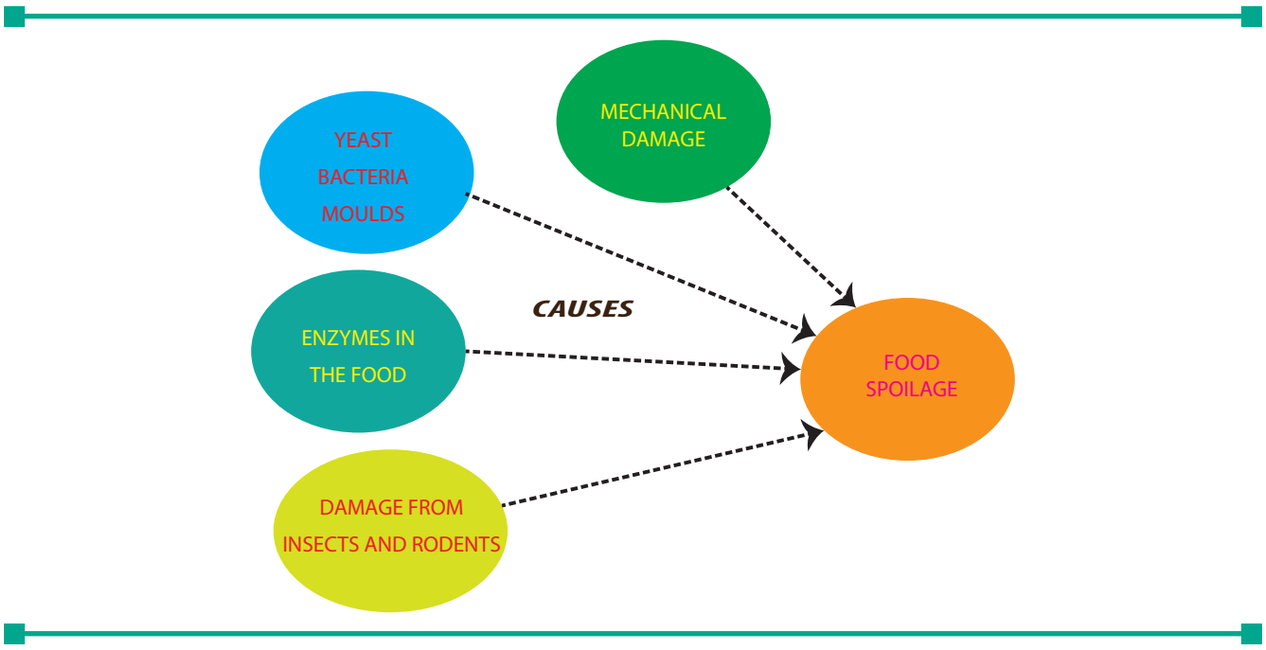


▲ Fig. 1 Causes of food spoilage

In order to prevent food spoilage and ensure food security and availability, various food preservation techniques have been used over the several years. The earliest steps in *food preservation* are *drying* of grains and nuts. Later *salting, smoking and drying* were applied to preserve the food.

4.1.1 Definition of Food Preservation

Food preservation is known as *"the science which deals with the process of prevention of decay or spoilage of food thus allowing it to be stored in a fit condition for future use".*

Preservation also can be defined *as "the state in which any food may be retained over a period of time without being contaminated by pathogenic organisms or chemicals, without losing optimum qualities of colour, texture, flavour and nutritive value".*

Importance of food preservation

Food production and supply does not always tally with the demand or needs of the people. In some places, there is *surplus production* of food product, whereas in some other place there is *inadequate supply*. It is therefore important to improve and expand *facilities for storage* and preservation of food to ensure its availability and acceptability at all times.

Preservation ensures:

- *Increase in shelf life of foods.*
- *Availability of seasonal foods throughout the year.*
- *Stability in prices of food as there will not be a deficit in supply.*
- *Good quality*
- *Edibility – texture and flavour*
- *Retention of nutritive value*
- *Retention of original colour of food.*

For the process of preservation, a preservative (e.g. salt, sugar, vinegar) is needed.

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